

on opposite sides in three major wars: the War of the Austrian Succession (1740–48), the Seven Years War (1756–63), and the American Revolutionary War (1775–83). After a shaky start, Britain's navy was clearly superior in the first of these. The Seven Years War was a hard-fought but overwhelming triumph of British naval power, allowing a major expansion of Britain's colonial empire. But the French navy achieved a remarkable recovery in the 1760s under the direction of Louis XV's chief minister the Duc de Choiseul, with a shipbuilding program funded by the French public inspired by patriotic enthusiasm. During the American Revolutionary War, facing a coalition of European powers supporting the rebellious American colonists, Britain suffered a crucial naval defeat at the hands of the French at Chesapeake Bay in 1781, although Rodney's victory at the Saints the following year redeemed the Royal Navy's reputation.

TECHNOLOGY AND TACTICS

During the 18th century two-deck 74-gun or 80-gun warships became established as the key ships of the line alongside 100-gun three-deckers. The French introduced a new breed of sleek frigate that became crucial to naval warfare, both as scouts and raiders. Cannon became more reliable, with a range of different shot, and experiments were made with replacing linstocks by flintlocks. The introduction of carronades by the Royal Navy in the 1770s—a lightweight upper deck gun potent at short range—increased the deadliness of close combat, as did improved muskets. The tactics employed in naval battles remained broadly unchanged, with broadsides forced by ships sailing in line, but some British commanders chafed at the formality of established rules and introduced the "general pursuit," allowing captains, when appropriate, to chase and engage the enemy in a free-for-all. Rodney's breaking of the French line at the Saints pointed forward to the Nelson era.



MAN-OF-WAR TACTICS

THE WEATHER GAGE

GUNNERY AND WIND DIRECTION

The British preferred to hold the weather gage in battle—that is, to fight from the windward side of the enemy. When they prevented the Spanish Armada from closing to board in 1588, they used the weather gage defensively, but it was above all an attacking position. While the French held a defensive line to leeward, the British would approach aggressively with the wind to engage them. During the approach they were exposed to French fire without being able to respond. On the other hand, the windward position meant smoke from cannon fire blew toward the enemy, giving the windward fleet better visibility. Lying to windward also favoured the British tactic of firing into the enemy's hull.

